



Andreeva prevailed 6-1, 6-3.

In 2021, Chwalinska, then 19, put her tennis ambitions and dreams on hold after a two-year battle with severe depression. She took a four-month break from tennis and took up boxing and running to recover from 'the unbearable sadness'. During her career-changing fortnight, she said, "The results don't define me as much as they did before. I just couldn't differentiate between Maja and the

tennis player. I was just one. I just needed time to kind of figure it out, and also do something else — not just tennis."

A knee injury at Wimbledon in 2022 sidelined Chwalinska for seven months and derailed her career again. Close followers of pro tennis may have noticed Chwalinska serving as the ice-bag girl for Swiatek, her longtime friend, at the 2026 United Cup in January.

Chwalinska arrived at Roland Garros ranked a lowly No. 114 with no career wins over top-50 opponents, no sponsors and short on funds.

So short, she could not afford to pay for her hotel room following her second-round win over 23rd-seeded Elise Mertens. Oshee, a Polish drinks company that sponsors Swiatek, came to the rescue.

Spectators chanted 'Maja, Maja, Maja' as she out-hit (32 winners), out-finessed (winning 14 of 17 points on drop shots or drop volleys), and out-steadied (only 11 unforced errors) Shnaider 7-6(4), 6-4 in a semifinal battle of crafty left-handers.

The underdog had become not only a crowd favourite in Paris but a national heroine. Incredibly, her last two matches attracted higher television ratings in Poland than all four of Swiatek's Roland Garros finals.

Class apart: Andreeva (above) broke Chwalinska's (below) lightweight serve seven times and blasted 25 winners.

AFP

"Iga and Maja are polar opposites," Maciej Ryszczuk, their co-physical trainer, told Polish journalists. "Iga is dynamic and always has been, while Maja is the kind of girl who solves forensic or mathematical puzzles on the court. She always knows how to answer her opponents. The truth is, everyone uses the skills they have and adapts their tennis accordingly, and we also adapt our physicality to that."

"Maja has a great overview of the court and a very high tennis IQ. She has all of this at a level currently unheard of in the top ranks of women's tennis. I think that's why she's causing such surprises now."

Alas, a fairy-tale ending was not to be. Andreeva broke Chwalinska's lightweight serve seven times and blasted 25 winners to her foe's 10.

Navratilova put it best: "All that variety doesn't work as well against a player as complete as Andreeva, an athlete, a jock. She wasn't bothered by her artistry and sophistry."

Even so, this Roland Garros will go down in history as much for Chwalinska's magical run as for Andreeva's maiden Major title.



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